

At a special birthday concert, maestro Amiya Ranjan Bandyopadhyay left the audience awestruck with the energy and aesthetics of his singing

Meena Banerjee

The 100th birthday celebrations of Sangeetacharya Amiya Ranjan Bandyopadhyay marked a momentous occasion in the history of Kolkata's classical music. For decades, his students have organised a special concert as part of his birthday celebrations, and each year he has unfailingly elevated its appeal with his khayal renditions. The Vivekananda Hall of the Ramakrishna Mission Institute of Culture was packed with admirers of the veteran musician. Clad in a dhoti-kurta, the centenarian took the stage with the same confidence that has defined his presence over the years. His singing belied his age. Beginning with a bada-khayal in Bihag set to Ektaal, he brought out the



Indomitable spirit The veteran was accompanied by Samar Saha on the tabla, and his disciples on the harmonium, tanpuras and vocals. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

never missed an opportunity to spot and encourage promising talent. This trait endeared him to Vijay Kichlu, the founder-director of the Sangeet Research Academy (SRA). At Kichlu's request, Amiya babu agreed to serve as a visiting member of SRA's expert committee to assess the progress of its scholars. During one such gradation test, he listened to a young Rashid Khan. So astounded was he by the boy's brilliance that he found himself unable to write anything in the review book. When requested to record at least a brief remark, he responded, "He is already a star musician. How can I assess him?"

On another occasion, he predicted that Chandana Chakraborty was a talent to watch out for. Today, she is an important member of Ajoy Chakrabarty's musical family. The evening echoed the very qualities he had long nurtured in others – now revealed through his own artistry. Accompanied by his favourite tabla artiste Samar Saha and a host of disciples on the harmonium, tanpuras and vocals, the sangeetacharya sat in sukhāsana like a yogi.

In tune at 100

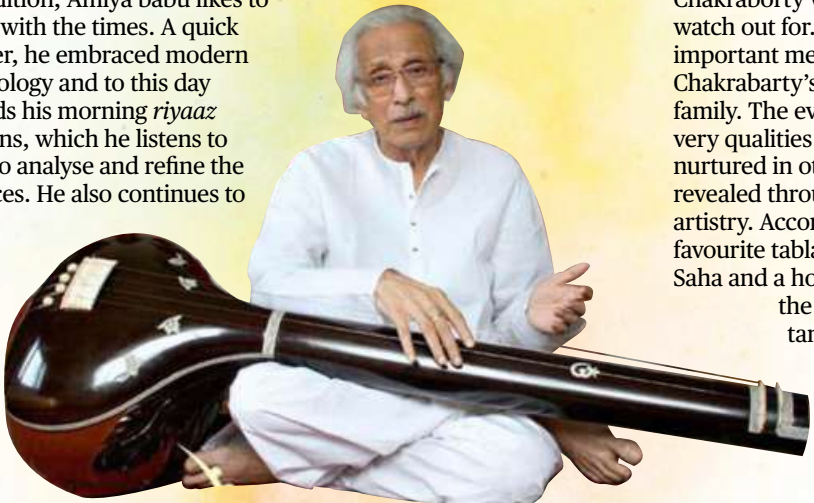
poignancy of the raag with remarkable finesse. The performance also reminded listeners of the significance of melodic aesthetics – an idea that forms the essence of his book *Sangeete Saundarya-Chinta*, written in Bengali. He followed it up with Drut Teentaal. The badhat

phrases were short but awe-inspiring. Without any repetition, he highlighted myriad shades of the raag and strung them lovingly with delicate meends. Similar were the taans that came about in lightning speed. Interestingly, apart from well-known names in the field

of music such as Ajoy Chakrabarty, Anindo Chatterjee and Samar Saha, several young music enthusiasts were also present. After a serene *guru-vandana* by Ramanuj Dasgupta, the audience was treated to an engaging session in which Shantanu Bandyopadhyay (Amiya babu's son) and a group of senior musicians recalled many facets of the maestro's life and art. Particularly striking is his deep admiration for Ustad Amir Khan's emotive yet intellectually rigorous approach to music-making. They also spoke about how he is a stickler for perfection and his deep sense of commitment. Despite hailing from a family of dhrupad singers,

Amiya babu, son of Satyakinkar Bandyopadhyay, chose to pursue khayal. Apparently, there would be complete silence in his house when he would sit to do his daily *riyaaz*. Though rooted in tradition, Amiya babu likes to move with the times. A quick learner, he embraced modern technology and to this day records his morning *riyaaz* sessions, which he listens to later to analyse and refine the nuances. He also continues to

teach more than 50 students both online and in-person. As a faculty member and later as the Head of the Department of Music at Rabindra Bharati University, he



Into a poet's world

Bahinabai Chaudhari's evocative verses became the focal point of Vaishnavi Dhore's performance

V.V. Ramani

The viewer was drawn into the world of poet Bahinabai Chaudhari in 'A woman beyond letters', a 45-minute choreographic production by Vaishnavi Dhore for the Jharna festival. Delving deep into the native milieu of the poet, Vaishnavi presented glimpses of her life and work through Bharatnatyam. Bahinabai, a cotton farmer widowed early with three children, faced life's hardships with great

determination. Her ruminations found expression in spontaneous outpourings of poetry and songs. Her verses traverse a wide spectrum of thought – her bond with Nature and family, reflections on life and devotion to Vittala. As the curtains went up, a lone spotlight symbolic of an altar space, framed the silhouette of a woman in prayer. The dancer, clad in a simple nine-yard Maharashtrian sari with minimal ornamentation, evoked the divine presence of Vittala and Rukmayi, the spiritual anchors of the

woman's life. Through the poems that followed, Vaishnavi's performance unveiled the varied facets of Bahinabai's journey. The dancer explored well the sequences that moved seamlessly from the world of realism, highlighted through a poem celebrating the weaver bird, its care, love and effort in building a nest, to an abstract concept, where the poet tries to unravel the mystery of the mind, before moving into the personal space, to depict grief and resilience. Vaishnavi's command over technique and



abhinaya was evident in the effortless ease with which she could communicate her ideas. However, there were a few areas that needed refinement. For instance, the long theeramanams that came at frequent intervals disturbed the flow of the narrative. Also, the imagery lacked a focal point, leaving the sequences without a connecting thread in the form of a recurring motif. The distinct voice of Shruthi Veena Vishwanath, as co-performer, added vibrancy to the choreography. Her rendition of the songs and the musical score beautifully captured the essence of the rural setting.

Evocative Vaishnavi Dhore PHOTO: J. JOHAN SATHYADAS

Beats that stir

Tal Fry, the percussion band, is all set for an exciting new performance season



V.V. Ramani

The core idea of the play was simple. Aadhi, a young parent entrusted to take care of his infant child, tries various tactics to keep the child happy and content. His efforts stir up memories of his own fragmented childhood, which have shaped his persona. To base a play just on this thought was no mean task, director Bhavya Balantrapu not only succeeded in accomplishing it but also made it relatable at varied levels. *In Other Words* was staged at the fifth edition of the Jharna festival. Three women, who were instrumental in moulding his personal and professional life were introduced to us through the eyes of Aadhi. The use of different languages to make it a multilingual experience, interlacing the dialogues with a touch of humour and the transition in musical phrasing for each segment were interesting facets that kept alive the momentum. Rosie, the English teacher, was a strict disciplinarian who placed great emphasis on perfect diction, pronunciation and grammar. This was conveyed through a classroom setting, where musical elements were used to highlight the teacher-student relationship. In stark contrast was the



Notes on life

Bhavya Balantrapu's play *In Other Words* used musical elements to depict memories and experiences

caretaker Meenamma, whose unconditional love and motivation made Aadhi understand the true meaning of freedom. Varied beats and sounds were incorporated to

capture these moments of joy. The rhythmic intonations, delivered through the actors' voices and expressions, whether solo or in chorus, effectively

Resonant tales Scenes from the play. PHOTOS: M. SRINATH



enhanced the scenes. The use of Tamil language added to the native flavour. Then there was Sonia, an office colleague and a mentor of Aadhi, who gradually moulds him to gain confidence and shapes his career. The dialogues in Hindi and the use of seven musical notes in different combinations and scales went well with the narrative. The actors sustained audience interest through their voice, body movements and acting skills. Mrityika,

Vichitra Menon and Gowthami Ashok, portrayed the characters with remarkable depth and came together to form the chorus when needed. As the protagonist Aadhi, Shravan Ramakrishnan brought out the distinct phases of the character with ease, through apt voice modulations and body language. His transition from the hyper-emotional state to the final moment of realisation, summed up his experiences. This was sensitively portrayed.

Neha Kirpal

Dynamic percussion ensemble Tal Fry's flagship production, *Rhythm Reimagined*, will be staged on March 27 at the Nita Mukesh Ambani Cultural Centre, Mumbai. Much like the name suggests, it hopes to offer a renewed take on Indian rhythms inspired by both Hindustani and Carnatic music. "While our approach and outlook is fresh, we are certainly not intent on reinventing the wheel – we will be presenting six compositions, some original and some inspired by maestros who we have all grown up listening to," says Manohar Balachandirane, the band's mridangam artiste. The key to Tal Fry's presentation is to push the envelope on how technology can help Indian music – and specifically percussion – sound better. "We use in-ear monitoring, a technology that eliminates stage noise and brings all us musicians closer on the aural plane. Apart from this, the use of dynamic lighting that complements and supplements our music has become a hallmark feature of our presentations," shares Varun, the band's ghatam artiste. Since its inception in 2024, the band has been fortunate to have found immense success. So far, they have performed at the World

Rainforest Music Festival in Malaysia and been contracted by Teamwork Arts, a premiere cultural and festival organising firm, to take their music across the country and the globe. "Our music also enables us to weave a narrative through rhythms, taking audiences from the classical to the folk, from north to south, and from the esoteric to the generic," says Aadarsh M. Nair, the band's Carnatic vocalist. Currently, Tal Fry is keen on working with artistes from other disciplines and forms, such as classical dance forms. "In the past, we have worked with Bharatanatyam dancers such as Manasvini Ramachandran and Madhura Bhrushundi. We are now working with two visual designers, Anandita Narayanan and Jaydeep Tirunagari, who will give our rhythmic forms some visual dimension," adds Saptak Sharma, the band's tabla player. Further, their most significant upcoming engagement is in July this year at the Fuji Rock Festival in Japan. Simultaneously, the band is working on a few Spotify single releases. They also have an all-India tour planned for November 2026 in which they hope to cover several cities, including Chennai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Pune, Kolkata, and of course their home turf, Delhi.



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In good humour

A birth centenary tribute to versatile actor V.K. Ramasamy, whose forte was comedy

Suganthy Krishnamachari

Will an aspiring 21-year-old actor, with a successful stage career, settle for a role as a villain in his first film? After all, every newcomer wants to be the hero. Wouldn't a young actor be afraid of typecasting? Not if the actor in question happens to be V.K. Ramasamy or VKR to his fans. He must have been supremely confident about his strengths as an actor, to agree to play a 60-year-old villain in his first film, *Naam Iruvar*, released in 1947. In this film, VKR leads dishonest Sarangapani down the garden path, promising that he will get his teenage daughter married to the old man. Eventually, it turns out to be a case of a 'diamond cutting a diamond', with the clever VKR proving to be more than a match for Sarangapani. You wouldn't guess this was VKR's first film. There is just the right mix of mockery and villainy in his portrayal of a stingy,



Flashback
(Clockwise from left) V.K. Ramasamy in *Paar Magale Paar* and *Kasi Yathirai*. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

sly old man, as he hoodwinks Sarangapani. In *Paar Magale Paar*, unable to bear Sivaji's taunts, he blurts out the truth about Sivaji's daughters, and the family is torn apart. With his changing expressions – humiliation, rage and remorse – VKR steals the scene. However, V.K. Ramasamy is best remembered for his comic roles, although he was seldom the main comedian. For instance, in *Ooty Varai Uravu*, Balaiah has more scenes than Ramasamy. VKR's character isn't even needed to stitch various scenes together to lead to the happy ending. And yet, once you have seen *Ooty Varai Uravu*, you cannot imagine a version of the film without Ramasamy. In *Kanni Thai*, when V.K. Ramasamy doesn't pay for the food in a restaurant, the restaurateur strips him of all his clothes, leaving him with just his dhoti. He feels embarrassed. But he is resourceful, and applies vibhuti all over his chest and steps out like a mendicant. The comic touch lies in the way he takes mincing steps to the tune of 'Nandavanathil oraandi'. Perhaps one of the few films in which



V.K. Ramasamy was the main comedian was *Kasi Yathirai*. But here again, there was a galaxy of comedians – Cho, Surulirajan, 'Thengai' Srinivasan, M.R.R. Vasu and Manorama. The film centres around Paramasivam Pillai (V.K. Ramasamy), a champion of bachelorhood and an iconoclastic opponent of romance. He is the guardian of his nephew and niece, both of whom have their respective romantic interests. The youngsters trap Ramasamy into writing a compromising letter to an actress (Manorama), which is then used for blackmailing him. VKR shows a tumult of feelings and portrays well

the battle between piety and long-suppressed desire. The complexion of the character Paramasivam Pillai keeps changing once he falls for Manorama, and V.K. Ramasamy's acting keeps pace with the changes. In *Kumara Vijayam* Ramasamy is caught in a trap because of an amatory affair years ago. A common enough situation in most Tamil films. But you don't mind the cliched situations, because you are chortling at VKR's sharp one liners. His avuncular attitude, when he regales Kamal's son with stories (film *Japanil Kalyanaraman*), is endearing. V.K. Ramasamy was a comedian with a difference. There was never any physicality to his comedy. He never indulged in horseplay. He didn't have to try hard to be funny. Just a grimace, or a chuckle, or the characteristic VKR guffaw, and he would have the audience eating out of his hands. There was a comic edge to the way he rendered his dialogues, sometimes even when he played a villain. Perhaps VKR enjoyed being a comedian. Otherwise, he could never have been so natural in comic roles. You often get the feeling that his comic lines were unscripted and came from his innate sense of humour. Comedy was indeed second nature to him.

CALENDAR

Annual festival

Hamsadhwani's 36th annual festival will feature Sandeep Narayan's vocal concert on March 15, 6.15 p.m. He will be accompanied by H.N. Bhaskar on the violin, Umayalpuram Sivaraman on the mridangam and Anirudh Athreya on the kanjira. Venue: Youth Hostel, Adyar.

Bharatanatyam solo

The Music Academy has organised the following programme on March 18 at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall. Details: Vaishnavi Srinivasan's Bharatanatyam recital 6 p.m. as part of the HCL concerts series.

Nagaswaram recital

The Music Academy will feature the Nagaswaram concert by Thirumakalam T.S. Pandian and Guruvayur S. Sreeram with Villupuram K.S. Kamaraj and Vedaranyam V.L. Harish accompanying them on the thavil. The recital, to take place on March 19, 6 p.m. at Kasturi Srinivasan Hall, is organised under the endowment, instituted by the families of Narayanan Nadadhur and Srinivasan Nadadhur, in the name of their parents Rajamma and N. Gopalaswami, former Chief Election Commissioner of India.



Tamil play

TV Varadarajan's United Visuals will stage *Sangeetha Mummoothigal*, a play on the Carnatic Music Trinity, on March 14, 6.30 p.m. at Kamakshi Kalyana Mandapam, Radha Nagar Chrompet; and on March 15, 6.30 p.m. at Mylapore Fine Arts Club.

Vocal concert

Madhuradhwani has organised the following programmes at Arkay Convention Center. Schedule: March 14, 6.15 p.m.: Jayakrishnan Unni (vocal). March 16, 6 p.m.: Release of the book *Gata Yogam* (Tamil translation of Sivananda Murthi's book written in English); 6.30 p.m.: Isai Kavi Ramanan's lecture series *Madham Thorum Maha Kavi*. March 18 to 20, 6.15 p.m.: Dr. Sudha Seshayyan's discourse 'Mahabharatam'.

Neha Kirpal

After the resounding success of his 'Silence in Sound' India tour in 2025, U.K.-based kirtan musician Radhika Das returns to India for his second edition. Beginning with Indore on April 3, he will perform in Jaipur on April 4 and in Gurugram on April 5. The performance focusses on mantra, meditation, reflective storytelling and immersive music. The performance will move beyond the traditional concert format to offer a collective meditative experience. "It will be an immersive kirtan experience where people will come together to chant, sing and reconnect. Every city brings its own energy and flavour of devotion, and it is inspiring to witness how ready the Indian audience is when it comes to collective chanting," says Radhika Das. The tour will include an international band, rich soundscapes and a specific set design, which seamlessly shifts through different emotional landscapes. "Each artiste brings his or her own musical background and texture to the sound," explains Radhika Das. Talking about his process for blending traditional mantras with modern music, Radhika Das says, "I begin with the chant, feeling its rhythm and emotion, before any musical arrangement takes shape. Once that is set, we explore instrumentation that support the mantra rather than overshadow it. Modern production becomes a way to expand the reach of the chant without altering its essence," he says. His upcoming EP continues to explore the idea of how kirtan can be reimagined to fit modern listening habits. "Traditionally, kirtans can be lengthy and meditative,



Chants for a new age

U.K.-based kirtan artiste Radhika Das returns to India with the next edition of his 'Silence in Sound' tour

which is beautiful in a live setting. With this EP, we experimented with a slightly shorter forms that weave in the divine names seamlessly into daily rhythms – playlists, car rides and routines. The intention is to keep the devotion intact while making the experience accessible to a wider audience," shares Radhika Das. He also believes that while music is one expression of the path, it is not the only one. Through retreats and workshops, Radhika Das creates spaces where people can go deeper into the philosophy. He also hosts conversations on his podcast 'For Soul's Sake', which explores spirituality, the

Bhagavad Gita, purpose and personal growth in an accessible way. His previous India tour witnessed a massive turnout with 15,000 attendees at the first show in New Delhi. "We travelled across multiple cities and witnessed some of the largest gatherings. What stood out was the diversity of the audience – from long-time practitioners to people attending their very first kirtan. Seeing thousands of voices singing the same mantra in unison was deeply moving. It reinforced the idea that devotional music still carries a powerful relevance in the modern world," shares Radhika Das.



Soul connect Radhika Das. (Above) during one of his performances. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND CECILIA CRISTOLEVEAN-CSIKY